Aetheln Online Game Design Bible

Document Status

This document is the canonical high-level product and gameplay direction for Aetheln Online. Detailed rules live in the linked system documents.

When older research or planning material conflicts with this document, this document wins. Names marked as working names still require a final creative and legal review.

Game Identity

Aetheln Online is a server-authoritative, third-person fantasy action MMORPG about two opposing factions struggling over the remaining light of a dying star.

The game combines:

- A persistent fantasy world with quests, dungeons, settlements, factions, and character progression.
- Mandatory open-world faction PvP once a character leaves protected faction territory.
- Pure-free-aim action combat built around aim, spacing, attack commitment, blocking, dodging, interruption, resource management, and readable animations.
- Equipment that creates meaningful power and utility without replacing player skill.
- Character development through Skein Weaving rather than a traditional point-by-point talent tree.

Design Pillars

Skill Decides How Power Is Used

Levels, equipment, Skein choices, and faction Doctrines provide real advantages. They do not aim, time a block, read a telegraph, manage Endurance, or choose a safe commitment for the player.

A skilled but moderately under-equipped player should be able to defeat an average better-equipped opponent. Extreme progression differences still matter, but the combat model must avoid routine one-hit victories and invulnerable defenders.

The World Becomes Dangerous by Progression

New characters begin inside their faction's protected territory. They learn their class, complete faction-specific quests, and build an initial identity without encountering rival players.

At a clearly communicated progression threshold, the story sends them into mixed territory. PvP there is always active outside explicit server-authoritative sanctuary subzones. There is no opt-in flag.

Challenge Produces Earned Progress

The game does not distribute constant low-value rewards to manufacture engagement. Rewards are less frequent, understandable, and materially useful.

Progress should be felt through:

- Increased damage, defense, resources, and recovery.
- New ability behavior and combo relationships.
- Better movement or traversal options within controlled limits.
- Stronger class and faction utility.
- Visible armor, weapon, and Ember-light changes.
- Access to more dangerous territory and more difficult encounters.

PvE and PvP Share One Combat Language

PvE teaches the same mechanics used against players. Normal enemies teach one verb, elites combine several verbs, and bosses test the complete vocabulary.

The primary verbs are:

- Aim.
- Position.
- Commit.
- Dodge.
- Block.
- Counter.
- Interrupt.
- Break guard.
- Control space.
- Protect allies.

Factions Are Different, Not Morally Simple

Both factions contain protectors, opportunists, idealists, and extremists. Neither side is the designated evil faction. The Ashen Choir remains a common enemy whose plan threatens the entire world.

All playable races can join either faction. Faction identity comes from belief, territory, quests, relationships, skills, utilities, and world goals, not biological restrictions.

Core Player Flow

1. Create a male or female character from any available playable race.
2. Select a faction and begin in its protected starting territory.
3. Learn movement, class combat, faction history, and early PvE mechanics.
4. Gain permanent Character Levels and unlock initial Skein options.
5. Enter mixed territory when the frontier threshold is reached.
6. Quest, gather, explore, fight enemies, and encounter hostile players under mandatory PvP rules.
7. Bank contested resources in a safe mixed city or faction holding.
8. Improve equipment, configure the Skein, and advance the faction Doctrine.
9. Join dungeons, world encounters, territorial battles, infiltration, or capital invasions.
10. Increase permanent power and seasonal Ember Rank, then challenge more dangerous regions.

World Structure

Protected Faction Territory

- Each faction owns a distinct starting territory and quest experience.
- Rival players cannot enter beginner districts through ordinary world travel.
- New characters are not valid PvP targets before reaching the frontier threshold.
- Faction capitals sit within these territories but have separate invasion rules.

Mixed Territory

- Both factions receive PvE quests and world objectives in the same regions.
- PvP is mandatory and always enabled except inside explicit server-authoritative sanctuary subzones.
- The game clearly communicates the transition before a player crosses it.
- Hostile-player risk raises the value of resources and rewards.
- Territory objectives provide stronger incentives than random killing.

Safe Mixed Cities

- Neutral cities allow both factions to trade, craft, form groups within their own faction, use services, and socialize.
- Cross-faction grouping is forbidden everywhere, including neutral safe cities (owner decision on Issue #115, 2026-10-11).
- Hostile abilities cannot be used inside their sanctuary boundaries.
- Leaving the boundary returns the character to the region's mandatory PvP rules.

Invasion-Enabled Faction Capitals

- Individual enemies may infiltrate through difficult routes.
- Organized forces may attack military objectives and attempt a full invasion.
- Beginner districts remain inaccessible to invaders.
- Guards and defenses make unsupported attacks dangerous.
- Invasions target gates, towers, barracks, commanders, and Ember stores rather than civilian NPCs.
- A successful invasion creates temporary consequences and rewards, not permanent denial of essential services.

Detailed world-PvP and invasion rules are defined in World and Settlements. Character loyalties and Faction Doctrine identities are defined in Characters and Factions.

Combat

Combat is third-person, action-based, and pure free aim. The player aims an authored attack; neither a soft lock nor a selected target determines authoritative contact.

Reticle mode is the default gameplay state: the cursor is hidden, a fixed center reticle expresses camera-directed aim, movement is camera relative, and the character turns smoothly toward camera-forward combat facing. Left mouse defaults to the primary attack and right mouse to the class defensive action; both bindings remain remappable. Space remains jump, including when a combo follow-up is available through its normal remappable ability binding.

Manual Left Alt toggling and future interface or dialogue layers may request Cursor mode. Those future layers must hold stacked cursor ownership so closing one layer cannot recapture the mouse while another still needs it. Cursor mode blocks new gameplay input; it does not pause gravity, erase momentum, cancel an accepted attack, or stop an authoritative combat timeline.

Shared Combat Grammar

Every Order uses the same five resource concepts. Display names may be localized, but their semantic identities and responsibilities do not change by Order, equipment, Form, Thread, Keystone, or faction Doctrine.

Resource	Stable semantic ID	Player-facing rule
Health	`combat.resource.health`	Remaining life. Reaching zero enters the server-authoritative death flow. Any future deliberate Health cost must be explicit rather than inferred from another resource.
Endurance	`combat.resource.endurance`	Shared exertion used by authored physical actions such as dodge, sprint, or demanding defense. An action spends it only when that action's data says so.
Guard	`combat.resource.guard`	Stability while actively defending. Guard pressure can break a block or defensive stance; Guard is not bonus Health and does not passively absorb every hit.
Ward	`combat.resource.ward`	Explicit temporary protection that absorbs only the damage its authored rule permits. Ward is separate from Health, Guard, armor, and invulnerability.
OrderResource	`combat.resource.order`	The one Order-specific combat currency slot. Its display identity is Grudge, Proof, Tempo, Cadence, or Tension according to the selected Order; it never aliases Endurance, Guard, or Ward.

Damage belongs to one of three stable families. **Wrought** (`combat.damage.wrought`) is material force: weapons, impacts, and other physical trauma. **Cinder** (`combat.damage.cinder`) is destructive Ember-light, heat, and burning transformation. **Wake** (`combat.damage.wake`) is Deepwake pressure that attacks continuity, memory, or realized form. An ability may contain more than one explicitly authored component, but the server resolves each component under its own family. Names do not imply fixed resistance values, bypasses, or status effects; those rules remain data driven and tuning-owned. No family is unmitigated "true damage," and content cannot bypass the shared defense order by relabeling a packet.

Combat resolves from authoritative state in a consistent order: action and world-policy eligibility, authored contact, avoidance or immunity, directional defense and Guard pressure, family-specific mitigation, eligible Ward absorption, remaining Health change, then secondary effects, interruption, and death. A Guard break affects later resolution only as its authored rule states; it never causes the same contact to be evaluated again. Simultaneous events use an explicit deterministic tie rule rather than frame or packet arrival order.

The shared effect language distinguishes immediate changes from duration effects and distinguishes helpful effects, harmful effects, and control. Every duration effect declares its stacking key, source scope, refresh or replacement behavior, maximum stacks, cleanse eligibility, and proc eligibility. A cleanse removes only effects in its authored cleanse set. **Resolve** is the shared server-owned

protection against repeated control: eligible control builds or consumes it according to authored data, while displacement, immunity, and uncontrolled damage remain separate concepts. Exact durations, stack limits, Resolve behavior, and all numeric values are tuning `TBD`.

Triggered effects form a bounded server-owned chain. A proc cannot recursively grant itself, create an unbounded cycle, or escape the root activation's finite listener, event, target, and construct budgets through branching, delay, or periodic work. A replayed activation cannot grant a second result. Exact proc budgets remain tuning `TBD`. Opponents receive readable cues for dangerous wind-up, active and recovery phases, defense, control, and meaningful state changes, without receiving secrets that secure stealth or anti-abuse rules intentionally withhold.

Relations, Engagement, and Recovery

- The server classifies a source/target pair as self, friendly, neutral, hostile, or protected/non-interactable for the current world-policy context. Party, faction, ownership, and sanctuary data are inputs; no client-provided relation or PvP flag is truth. Projectiles, areas, summons, and other proxies inherit an authoritative source identity and recheck current policy when their result would apply.
- Movement collision, combat query volumes, and presentation geometry are separate. Character meshes and rendered weapons never become authoritative collision merely because they overlap on a client.
- Engagement is server-owned state derived from validated hostile actions, damage, healing, protection, threat, and encounter rules. It is not a player toggle and does not end merely because a client disconnects.
- PvE threat is a server-owned input to AI target choice. A taunt is an authored temporary priority rule for eligible AI, not selected-target combat authority and never control of another player's input.
- Resource recovery can be passive, delayed, event-driven, or supplied by an authored restoration effect. Ability recovery windows and cooldowns are separate from resource recovery. Exact rates, delays, and reset values are `TBD`.
- Death and respawn clear or preserve only explicitly authored state. Logout, disconnect, reconnect, and encounter reset cannot be used to duplicate a grant, erase an accepted hostile result, or revive stale attacks, threat, effects, or invulnerability.
- Stealth and detection are server decisions. A concealed opponent's hidden state must not be disclosed through UI, targeting, replication, audio, or effects before the observer is authorized to perceive the corresponding cue.

Prototype Combat Boundary

The prototype remains one Oathscar using sword and shield in one controlled combat space. It exercises only the shared grammar needed for Health, Endurance, active Guard, a three-hit Wrought combo, directional block, dodge, three representative active abilities, one enemy, death, respawn, and readable feedback. Issue #107 may define one optional Oathbreak exercise; it does not make Grudge

or the full OrderResource loop default prototype scope. Ward, Cinder, Wake, generalized threat and taunt, full effect and cleanse collections, full Resolve tuning, stealth gameplay, faction relations, and the other four Orders remain defined future-compatible concepts, not prototype runtime scope.

This grammar does not take over runtime or evidence ownership. Networking and authority selection remain with Issue #2; dodge with #18; GAS attributes, effects, resources, and cooldowns with #19; death and respawn with #21; threat controls with #40; measured budgets with #45; the attack timeline and combo with #60; HUD and readability with #61; and input/camera feel with #82.

This Issue-#105 grammar is the approved source contract for the four canonical documents updated here. It replaces the pre-Issue-#103 placeholder phrase `prototype combat resource` and the earlier instruction not to canonize Guard; the prototype brief, scope ledger, supporting artifacts, and prototype roadmap now name Health, Endurance, and active Guard. Issue #115 owns any remaining downstream brief, ledger, roadmap, glossary, generated-artifact, and board reconciliation. Historical evidence keeps the terminology it recorded at the time and is not silently rewritten.

Authoritative Rules

- The server decides movement validity, hits, damage, healing, resources, cooldowns, crowd control, death, loot, and PvP rewards.
- Clients may predict supported local movement, GAS activation, animation, and reversible presentation, but never a hit or persistent outcome.
- Melee attacks use server-resolved swept volumes during authored windows on a server-owned attack timeline. Those authored volumes match the readable animation; rendered-weapon or character-mesh collision is not gameplay truth.
- Projectiles and persistent combat areas are server owned.
- Dodges grant a server-validated defensive window.
- Blocks are directional and consume a defensive resource.
- Ability-authored movement restrictions provide commitment. Individual attacks may restrict movement differently rather than sharing a universal immobilization rule.
- Input buffering supports deliberate combo timing without automating the rotation.
- Animation notifies, sockets, effects, audio, and camera feedback visualize the authoritative timeline but do not create gameplay truth.
- The server never accepts a client-selected target or claimed contact.
- Shoulder framing, close-camera offsets, and mesh hiding are presentation only. They never alter attack origins, hitboxes, reach, timing, or collision.

Readability Rules

- Dangerous actions have readable animation and effects.
- Range, direction, and impact timing must be learnable.
- Crowd effects cannot obscure critical telegraphs.

- Visual character differences must not change the authoritative combat capsule or create male, female, or race-based hitbox advantages.

Playable Orders

Orders are the game's classes: surviving institutions that train the Emberbound. Under Issue #104, the five Orders below supersede the earlier four initial class concepts (Bulwark, Skeinblade, Embercaller, and Lumen), and Oathscar supersedes Skeinblade as the active initial Order working label. Every display name below is a working name with a stable semantic ID.

- **Oathscar** (`order.oathscar`): greatsword, sword-and-shield, two-handed spear, and dual wield; sworn grudges spent as the Grudge resource; standing ground, guard pressure, and punishment.
- **Nullwright** (`order.nullwright`): staff, focus gauntlet, grimoire-blade, and orbiting seals; demonstrated claims banked as the Proof resource; aimed bursts, zones, and unmaking forced history.
- **Hushblade** (`order.hushblade`): twin knives, sheathed blade, chain-sickle, and needle fan; stolen rhythm banked as the Tempo resource; dodging, momentum, pursuit, and recovery punishment.
- **Gravecant** (`order.gravecant`): chime-staff, mace-reliquary, chain-censer, and tome-rod; measured song banked as the Cadence resource; healing, wards, witness-keeping, and battlefield tempo.
- **Blackfletch** (`order.blackfletch`): longbow, recurve bow, greatbow, and tether/trap bow; drawn stillness banked as the Tension resource; range, traps, tethers, and route control.

Each Order has two specializations and one Peak; a specialization selects the dominant interpretation of the Order's oath, and a Peak briefly realizes a forbidden version of the character. Resource names are working names and all resource behavior is tuning TBD; the shared resource identities and prototype subset are defined by the combat grammar above.

Orders are not faction-locked. Faction Doctrines modify how an Order approaches the world and combat without replacing its identity. The full Order institutions, specializations, Peaks, and character connections are defined in Characters and Factions.

Character Development

Character Level

Character Level is permanent. It governs base growth, ability access, equipment requirements, and Skein unlocks.

The level cap, exact progression curve, and unlock levels remain tuning decisions. They must be data driven.

Ember Rank

Ember Rank represents story recognition, faction-war participation, and seasonal achievement. It may compress or reset between Ember Cycles without removing permanent Character Levels.

Skein Weaving

Skein Weaving replaces a traditional WoW-style talent tree.

Its initial elements are:

- **Forms:** mutually exclusive behavior changes for class abilities. In lore, a Form is an alternate history of a technique drawn from the Deepwake.
- **Threads:** limited links in which one successful combat action changes another. In lore, a Thread binds a remembered cause to its consequence.
- **Keystone:** one major rule that changes the class's combat rhythm. In lore, a Keystone accepts one defining contradiction into the character.
- **Faction Doctrine:** faction-specific active and utility development.

The initial playable implementation should use a small number of meaningful choices rather than many percentage nodes.

Detailed rules are defined in Progression, Loot, and Skein Weaving.

Equipment and Loot

Equipment supports every part of combat:

- Offensive power and damage type.
- Health, protection, and resistance.
- Endurance, Guard, Ward, OrderResource, and recovery.
- Attack cadence and ability recovery within controlled limits.
- Stagger, guard pressure, healing, and support.
- Conditional class, faction, PvE, PvP, traversal, and siege utility.

Equipment must not invalidate aiming, timing, positioning, or defensive execution. Raw movement-speed and cooldown stacking require strict caps because they can break animation readability and network fairness.

Loot generation is server-side, transactional, auditable, and data driven. Encounter difficulty, territory danger, contribution, source identity, and mastery conditions may improve rewards. Equipped items do not drop on PvP death. Characters may lose a controlled portion of unbanked contested resources.

Character Creation

Full character creation is a future system, but data and animation architecture must account for it from the beginning.

Confirmed rules:

- The confirmed playable peoples are Aurin, Kell, and Vesh. The Waking Star dreamed each people separately, all three predate the Duskbreak, and no confirmed account identifies which was dreamed first.
- Kell are living crystalline people with ivory-quartz outer plates, dark amethyst connections, swept horns, external pointed ears, glowing violet eyes, and clawed extremities. Their approved male and female references and full anatomy contracts are recorded in Playable Peoples.
- Vesh are mortal embodied spirit creatures connected to the world's spirits and guided by the Light. The approved 2026-10-13 design uses an obsidian-black coat, white sculpted fur markings, an ivory faceted natural face with a neutral creature mouth, golden eyes, clawed three-digit hands, and digitigrade legs with three-toed clawed paws. Their spiritual kinship supplies no innate gameplay advantage; Playable Peoples defines the full contract.
- Every playable race supports male and female characters.
- Sex does not change attributes, combat power, class access, faction access, or authoritative hitboxes.
- Every playable race may use every supported class.
- Every playable race may join either player faction.
- Appearance data is separate from class, faction, progression, equipment, and combat state.
- Planned appearance categories include race, sex, body preset, constrained visual height, age presentation, face, skin, markings, voice, and a race-discriminated feature set.

Before the 2.0 faction stage, persisted characters use `Faction = Unassigned`. Doctrine is unavailable until the approved one-time faction choice. This delivery state does not change the target-game flow in which a faction character begins in its protected territory.

Detailed anatomy, culture, customization, rig, animation, equipment-fitting, and art-validation rules are defined in Playable Peoples.

Lore Spine

Before the world there was the Deepwake, an ocean of unrealized lives and histories - everything that could have happened and did not. The Waking Star emerged from it: a partly sentient memory engine that dreamed Aetheln into physical existence by realizing some histories and rejecting the rest. Whether the Star intends anything by what it realizes remains disputed, and that dispute is deliberate canon. The Star's light is the source of life, magic, and memory.

The Star dreamed the Aurin, Kell, and Vesh separately. All three peoples predate the Duskbreak, and their creation order remains unknown.

The Vesh were dreamed as spirits with tangible lives and bodies of their own. They follow the Light through listening, compassion, and responsible judgment. The spirits they meet are local continuities of realized lives and places; their testimony can be incomplete, mistaken, or refused. Neither an encounter nor the Vesh's existence settles the Star's intention. Enlightenment is a practice rather than moral infallibility, and neither faction owns the Light. The Duskbreak fractured the histories many spirits carry. Selaen's caravans and Lanternrest's Mother-Lanterns now gather willing witnesses and care for places whose continuity is fading. In the Quieting, the Ashen Choir erases distinct voices into a single account, drawing Nhalen and Saeril into the conflict between preservation, consent, and certainty.

The Kell were dreamed as living layered crystal. Their long lives leave growth and repair visible in quartz and amethyst, shaping a cultural argument over continuity through change. Their bodies do not automatically store readable memories; preservation is learned craft. Graefell remembers their first awakening before its canyon was glassed. Vothram's ritual instruments and secret archive turn care into a question of responsibility and ownership, while Corvath's exceptional birth as living catastrophe glass confronts his people with life preserved at the cost of its next change.

The Lucent Choir attempted the Great Concordance: binding the Star's light permanently and forcing incompatible histories to coexist. The Concordance caused the Duskbreak, cracking the Star and glassing much of civilization. The wounded Star now sheds scarce Embers - rejected memories seeking realization - into the world. Forgettings are what remains when a life or place loses its continuity: still present, no longer coherent. The Emberbound, who carry realized Embers, respawn from their last coherent witnessed record.

The Concord was created to regulate those Embers, but its laws are severe and its control is disputed. The two player factions now disagree over who should control the remaining light and what survival justifies.

The Ashen Choir seeks to complete the failed ritual. Its Choirmaster believes a completed Concordance - the Onefold Vault - can end suffering; the Waking Star never clearly commands him. The Choir's success would extinguish the Star and end all life.

Reward Philosophy

Rewards should be earned, legible, and useful.

- Routine enemies primarily support materials, currency, and occasional equipment.
- Elites and difficult encounters offer stronger and more distinctive rewards.
- Bosses provide reliable progress plus a chance at signature items.
- Contested territory adds risk-based reward value.
- Mastery conditions may add reward opportunities without removing the base completion reward.
- Extreme random outliers require a fairness mechanism so a player is not trapped indefinitely, but the game should not shower the player with constant consolation rewards.
- Earlier enemies should become meaningfully easier as permanent power grows.

Development Scope

The target game includes faction territories, mandatory mixed-territory PvP, safe neutral cities, faction-capital invasions, progression, equipment, Skein Weaving, PvE, and persistent online services.

The current prototype does not build that entire game at once. It first proves:

- Responsive replicated movement.
- One representative Order kit; Oathscar is the active initial Order working label, superseding Skeinblade.
- Server-authoritative attacks, dodge, damage, death, and respawn.
- One enemy and one controlled combat space.
- Playability under representative latency and packet loss.

Later vertical slices introduce cooperative PvE with minimal permanent progression, then inventory, equipment, Character Levels, and initial Skein Weaving, then faction identity with one contested region, and finally capital-invasion systems. Deferring a target feature from the prototype does not make that feature optional in the final game.

Open Decisions

The following require dedicated design decisions and must not be guessed:

- Final faction names and heraldry.
- Frontier unlock level.
- Level cap and progression curve.

- Faction-switching rules. Cross-faction grouping is decided, not open: forbidden everywhere, including neutral safe cities (owner decision on Issue #115, 2026-10-11).
- Item slots, rarity names, trading, binding, and economy rules.
- Exact PvP death loss and contested-resource banking rules.
- Territory population balancing and outnumbered-faction support.
- Capital-invasion schedule, scale, victory state, and recovery duration.
- Skein slot counts, unlock cadence, and class-specific Forms.
- Relationship between Character Level and Doctrine prerequisites.
- Ember Cycle duration and seasonal reset details.